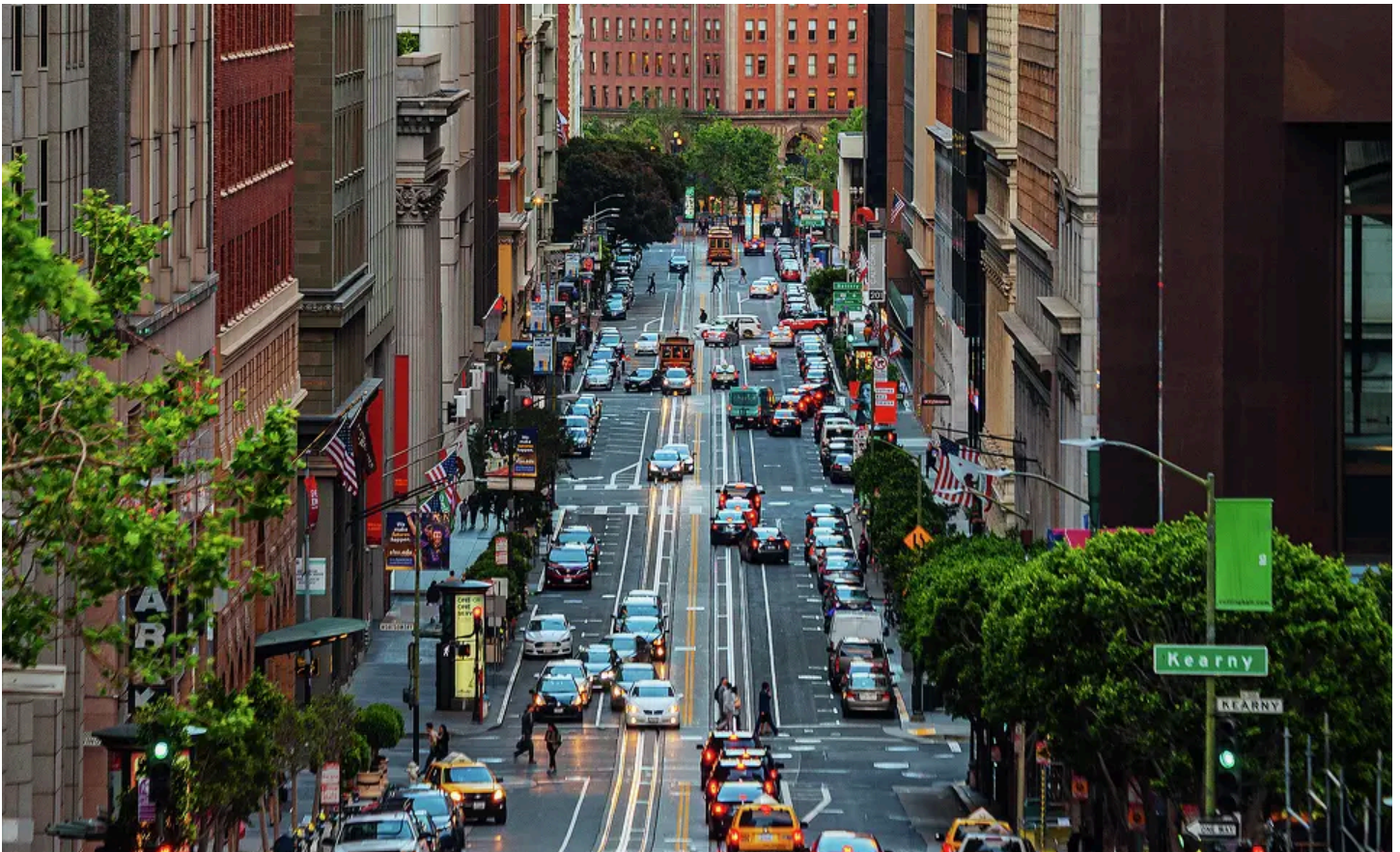


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How to avoid San Francisco's new automatic speeding tickets

By **Madilynne Medina**, News Reporter
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SF's speed cameras are now issuing real tickets. Here's what to know.

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San Francisco drivers will be wise to stay under the speed limit starting Tuesday as the city begins to automatically issue fines with tickets for those caught speeding.

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Though the 33 automated speed cameras around San Francisco went live in March, up until now, drivers caught going too fast were issued only warnings as part of a several monthslong grace period meant to acquaint them with the new system. But now, the citations that will land in your mailbox will come with penalties that range from \$50 to \$500.

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Here's what to know about the new cameras:

Where are the new cameras?

The speed enforcement cameras are scattered around the city on streets that are the most prone to traffic injuries, have a history of sideshows or are in school zones, according to the [San Francisco Municipal Transportation Agency](#). A map and list of the 33 camera locations is on [SFMTA's site](#).

[As of Tuesday](#), all of the cameras are installed and operational. Erica Kato, an SFMTA spokesperson, told SFGATE that the cameras are visible to drivers. Anyone using [Google Maps](#) or [Apple Maps](#), both of which include speed camera locations in navigation directions, may receive a warning from their navigation system as well. Though neither Google nor Apple responded to SFGATE's questions about whether they've already added the SF camera locations to their systems, when SFGATE drove by a camera last

Any vehicle going at least 11 mph over the posted speed limit is going to be stuck with a fine.

SFMTA will automatically mail speeding tickets to the registered owner of the vehicle, but the amount of the fine depends on how fast drivers are going. The citations will only be a civil penalty and won't show up as a DMV point.

For drivers going 11 to 15 mph over the limit, the fine is \$50. Those going 16 to 25 mph over the limit will receive a \$100 ticket, and drivers going 26 mph or more over the limit will receive a \$200 ticket. Any vehicle going 100 mph or more in any location will be fined \$500. To pay the fine, drivers can visit the SFMTA speed safety camera payment portal.

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Some drivers may qualify for a lower fee, such as low-income drivers or those participating in public assistance programs like SNAP and Medi-Cal. Low-income drivers can apply for the fee waiver on the agency's site. SFMTA's speed camera site

Kato said that as with other citations from the agency, drivers can appeal the speeding tickets. And according to SFMTA, drivers can perform community service instead of paying the ticket. In the case that someone's car is stolen and they receive an automatic speeding ticket, drivers will be able to submit an affidavit of nonliability, according to the agency.

Where have people been getting the most tickets?

Since the cameras went live in March, SFMTA said three-month data from the warning period shows that drivers are already slowing down. Speeding dropped by more than 30% between the first week and the seventh week of the period, SFMTA said in a news release shared with SFGATE.

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About half of the warnings were sent to San Francisco residents, the release said. After receiving one warning, more than 70% of drivers have not been issued a second

The intersections with the most improvement include Fulton Street between Arguello Boulevard and Second Avenue, with a 63% decrease in speeding. When the cameras launched, about 4 in every 100 vehicles were speeding, and by week 13, fewer than 2 per 100 vehicles were speeding.

Geneva Avenue, between Prague Street and Brookdale Avenue, and Bayshore Boulevard, between the Highway 101 off-ramp and Tunnel Avenue, also saw drastic shifts in driver behavior. The two intersections had a 45% and 40% decrease in speeding, respectively.

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A [public dashboard](#) last updated on June 30 shows that Fulton Street between Arguello Boulevard and Second Avenue had the most violations, with 17,626 warnings issued. The intersection with the second most was Bryant Street between 2nd and 3rd streets, with 14,158 warnings sent.

SFMTA also [released data](#) showing which intersections had the most speeding drivers in April (Data analysis from May, June and July is not yet available.) That month, the

SFTMA also found that a majority of the speeders, 77%, were driving 11 to 15 mph over the posted limit. The most speeding happened during morning commute times, from 7 to 8 a.m., and the day with the most violations was Tuesdays.

Though the recent data shows improvement, Robert Schneider, a former Bay Area resident who is now a professor of architecture and urban planning at the University of Wisconsin–Milwaukee, told SFGATE that it’s important to consider how many cars pass through the city’s concentrated streets every day. At Geneva Avenue, for example, where the speed limit is 30 mph, 14 in 100 vehicles were reported speeding per day when the cameras first launched, according to SFMTA data.

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“Another way to think about that is if there is a street that has 10,000 vehicles per day, and I think Geneva is slightly above that, that translates to 1,400 vehicles per day traveling at 40 mph,” he said.

How are the cameras different from other

throughout the city. The cameras have been operating since the 1990s, and the agency plans on expanding the network in the future.

Vehicles running red lights are detected with a 3D traffic radar that takes a photo of the rear views of the vehicle, a close-up of the license plate and the driver. Tickets from the red-light cameras range from \$100 to \$500.

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The other network of cameras, called ALPRs, or automatic license plate readers, is operated by the San Francisco Police Department for surveillance and tracking down crime suspects. There are 400 AI-powered cameras set to be installed across the city, with at least 100 of those already live.

What do the cameras photograph exactly?

According to [California Assembly Bill 645](#), legislation passed in 2023 that authorized the cameras. the new speed cameras aren't allowed to use facial recognition. SFMTA

San Francisco is the first city in the state to officially launch the program, but the Legislature authorized the program in Los Angeles, San Jose, Oakland, Glendale and Long Beach. The pilot program will operate until January 2032, according to the bill text.

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Why do officials believe the program is important?

The cameras, which are part of a five-year program, are intended to reduce several and fatal traffic collisions, SFMTA said on its site. The agency said speeding is the number one cause for collisions that result in injuries in the city.

San Francisco has been trying to mitigate traffic deaths for over a decade with its Vision Zero program. The initiative, adopted in 2014, aimed to help the city reach zero traffic deaths by 2024. But the city failed to reach that goal, and recorded its deadliest year in more than a decade for pedestrians in 2024. City leaders, though, are banking

Administration that shows that slower speeds have consistently led to fewer crashes, deaths and injuries.

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“You have less of a likelihood that somebody will die if the speed of the car that they’re hit by is slower, so it’s purely physics,” Schneider said.

He added that the recent data also shows a shift in driver behavior on the streets with and without cameras, which he expects will accelerate.



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helping change the driver's mindset into one that's a more aware mindset about traffic safety and about their neighbors on the streets."

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In addition to improving safety, he said he hopes the cameras will make San Francisco streets more comfortable for pedestrians.

"When cars are going slower, [streets] become more welcoming and more comfortable places to be," he said. "... People will be less afraid to go out in their cars, but also especially go out on the streets, walking and biking, and that is really important."

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